FOUNDER OPERATING PLAYBOOK

Founder-Led Growth Operating System

A practical system for keeping founder judgement where it matters while removing the founder as the default bottleneck.

Use with	The editable Excel operating-system workbook included with this guide
Time required	90 minutes to install, then 30 minutes per week
Outcome	Clear ownership, a visible decision queue, a weekly rhythm, and staged handoffs

Founder-led is useful. Founder-dependent is expensive.

Founders carry context, taste, category judgement, and relationships that should not be delegated casually. The problem begins when every routine growth decision also waits for the founder.

- **Keep:** category point of view, major positioning trade-offs, top customer relationships, and irreversible strategic choices.
- **Share:** quarterly priorities, budget allocation, and high-risk experiments.
- **Hand off:** weekly sequencing, campaign briefs, channel optimisation, reporting, and routine vendor direction.

1. Map decisions, not tasks

Task delegation does not create operating ownership. Use the Ownership Map to name the current owner, intended owner, founder role, readiness, and next evidence required.

Founder role	Meaning
Own judgement	The founder remains the decision-maker because unique judgement is the advantage.
Approve	The owner recommends; the founder accepts or rejects against explicit criteria.

Founder role	Meaning
Consult	The owner decides after seeking context from the founder.
Informed	The owner decides and reports the outcome in the agreed rhythm.

2. Install a weekly rhythm

A healthy system creates fixed moments for evidence, decisions, and delivery. It reduces interruption without hiding important information.

When	Moment	Founder involvement
Monday	Read signal and set the week's focus	Reads a one-page summary
Tuesday	Brief work against the decision rule	Only on founder-judgement items
Wednesday	Ship	None by default
Friday	Keep, change, stop, or scale	Approves exceptions
Monthly	Reallocate priority, budget, or ownership	Leads judgement

3. Run a visible decision queue

Make waiting legible. Every open decision needs one owner, a deadline, a statement of whether founder input is required, and the evidence needed to decide.

- If everything is P1, nothing is P1.
- If a decision repeatedly waits for the founder, change the decision right or the information flow.
- If the team brings problems without recommendations, the owner probably lacks a threshold or sufficient context.
- Close decisions in the queue even when the answer is 'not yet'. Ambiguity should be explicit.

4. Hand off in two stages

A durable handoff transfers context, guardrails, and review rules. Use a shadow week followed by a reverse-shadow week.

Stage	What happens
Shadow	The new owner observes how the founder frames evidence and trade-offs.
Reverse shadow	The new owner makes the decision; the founder observes and asks questions.
Operating ownership	The new owner decides inside the agreed threshold and reports through the rhythm.
Exception review	The founder only re-enters when the threshold, risk, or strategic priority changes.

5. Use the dependency check as a monthly leading indicator

Score each statement 0–2. The total is not a judgement of the founder; it is a read on whether the system can keep moving.

- **0–6, healthy:** protect the rhythm and document the judgement that still matters.
- **7–13, fragile:** hand off one decision layer this month.
- **14–20, founder-dependent:** install ownership and a weekly decision cadence immediately.
- Repeat monthly and look for movement in specific statements, not just the total.

The one-page installation sequence

Week	Install
1	Complete the dependency check and map the ten most common growth decisions.
2	Name the system owner and start the Monday / Friday rhythm.
3	Create the decision queue and hand off one routine decision through shadowing.
4	Reverse-shadow, confirm thresholds, and remove one recurring founder approval.

A useful test

If the founder disappeared for one week, would growth work stop, drift, or continue inside clear priorities and decision thresholds? The operating system is working when the answer is: continue, with the exceptions waiting visibly.